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COLLEGE 117
April 13, 2026
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Social Determinants of Health & Justice

Recap of last Monday:



Genetic Determinism

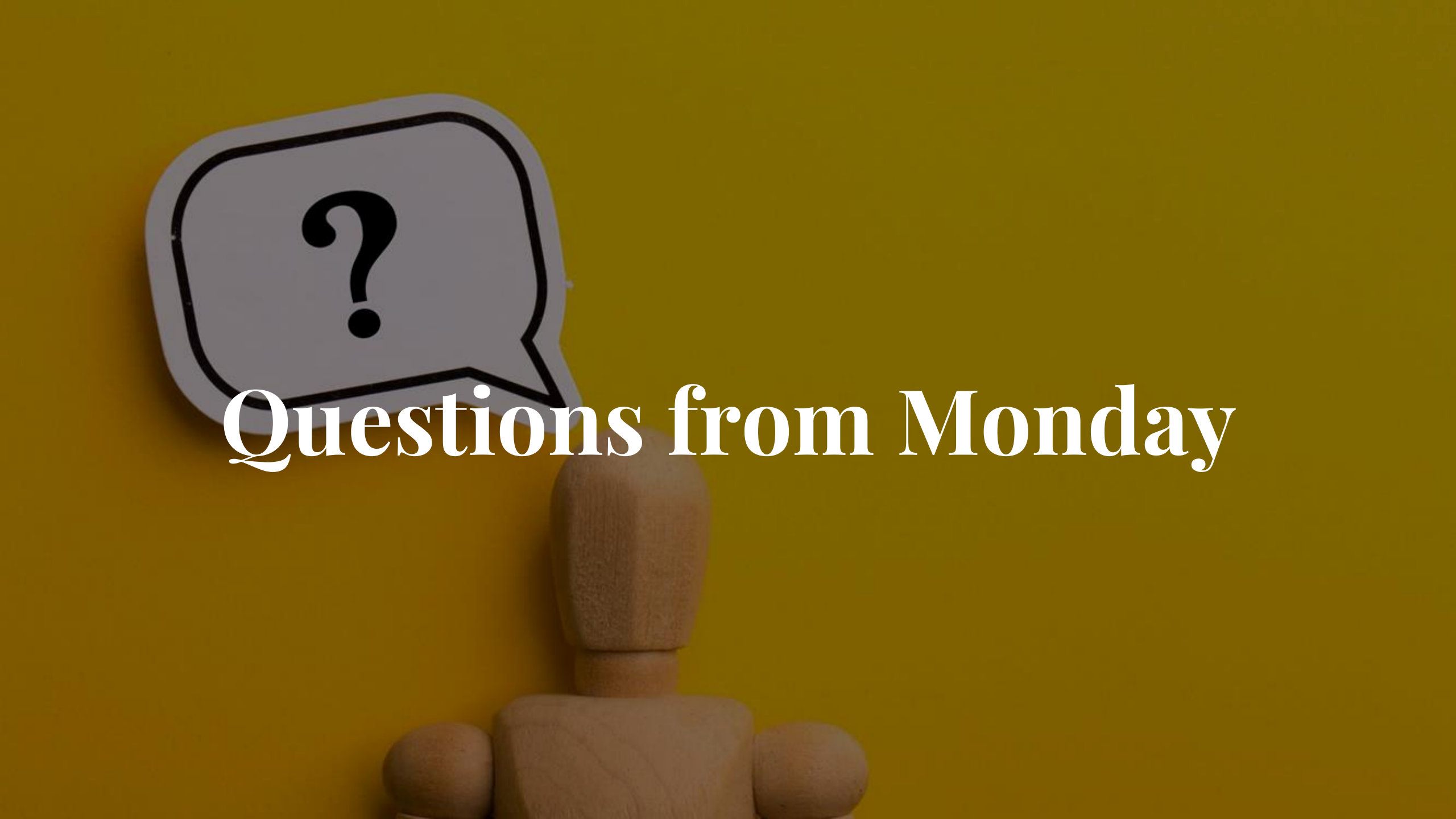
- The view that genes are fixed, immutable, and can be used to divide people into discrete, non-overlapping groups (Dar-Nimrod & Heine, 2011)

Racial Essentialism

- The view that members of a group share defining qualities, or essences, that are innate and unchanging and inform the nature, behavior, or abilities of group members (Roth, 2023)

Strategic Essentialism

- Genetics are used in ways that serve people's pre-existing beliefs and agendas



Questions from Monday

Distinguishing between essentialism & determinism

- **Genetic essentialism:** Genes are fixed entities that constitute the essence of what we are.
- **Genetic determinism:** Genes invariably determine phenotypes, so that the outcomes are just a little, or not at all, affected by the changing environments in which individuals live.

There is a lot of semantic slippage between these two terms



Distinguishing between essentialism & determinism

- Can believe that a person's "essence" is genetic (essentialism) while acknowledging that environment and choice can change the final outcome (no determinism).
    - Believing someone is "naturally an athlete" (essentialism) does not dictate they will be successful without training (non-deterministic)

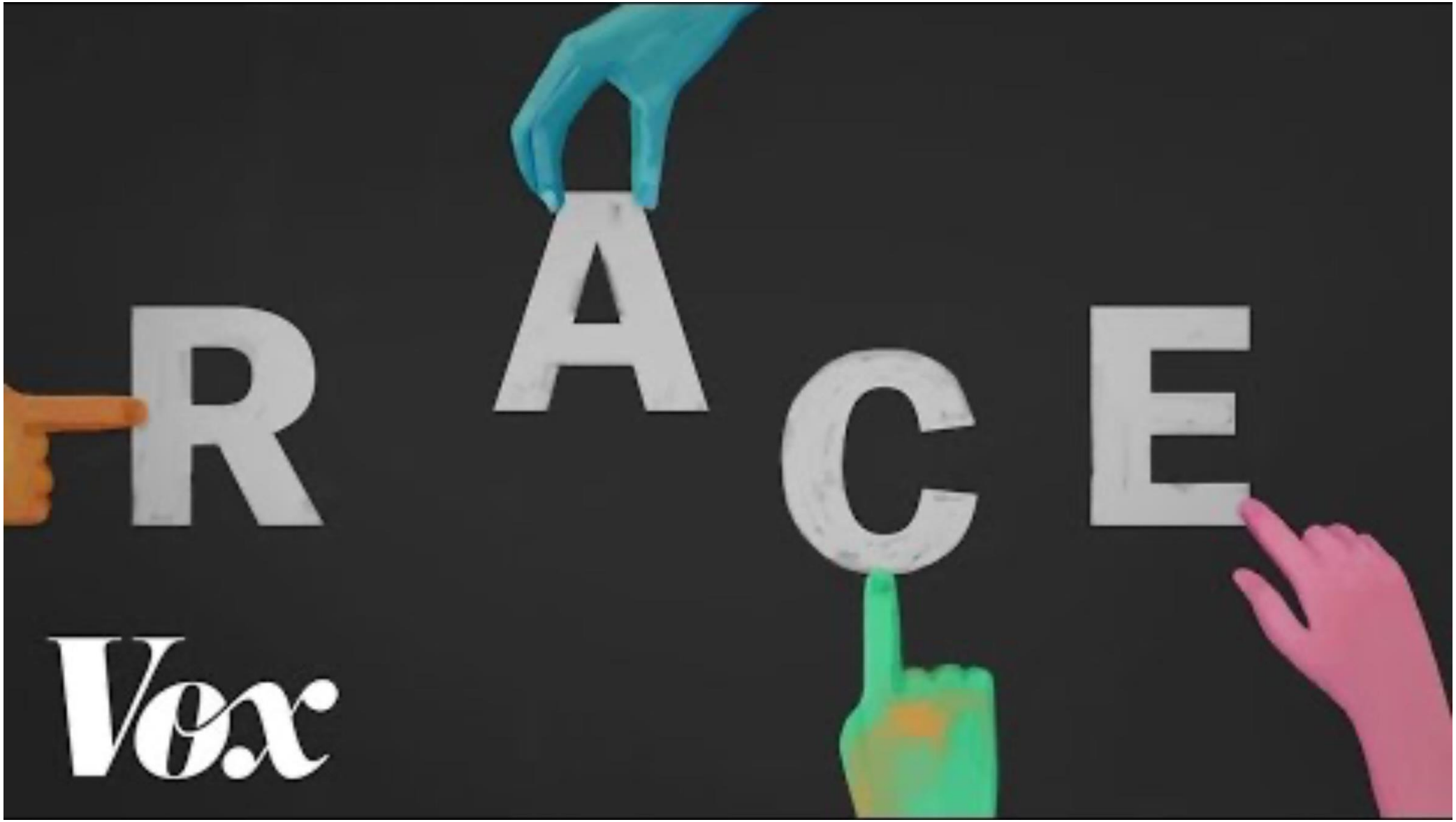




Race & biology

A person's DNA influences a variety of aspects of their appearance. **Some physical features, like skin color or hair texture are biologically influenced.** These features also **carry social meaning-** they are used to tie a person to a racial classification.

Imagine a world where we classify people and organize society not according to skin color or hair texture but height, or hair color, or whether they have flat feet or arched feet. In such a world, the DNA variants associated with skin pigmentation would not function as a categorizing variable.


RACE
Vox

“It is well established that race and ethnicity are not valid biological markers, but there is a lack of consensus as to whether and how they should be used in research studies or in medical decision making” (NASEM, 2024)

BOX S-1
Concepts Related to Race and Ethnicity

Race and ethnicity categories are often used as proxies for the true concepts or variables of interest. In addition to self-identified race and ethnicity, researchers may choose to investigate:

- Relational aspects of race
- Structural racism
- Social determinants of health (e.g., environment)
- Ethnic and cultural practices (e.g., language, religion)
- Immigration status and degree of acculturation
- Indigeneity
- Skin color and pigmentation
- Known ancestry
- Genetic markers, genetic variation
- Social and stress-related biomarkers
- Other biomarkers and biological indicators

How can essentialism be reduced?

HGG Advances

REVIEW We're right here

Ending genetic essentialism through genetics education

- Between the ages of 5 and 10 years, evidence suggests that US elementary schoolers stop thinking of racial identity as subjective and flexible and they begin to think of it as natural and stable
- Adolescence is when people begin to favor genetic explanations for racially stereotyped traits like intelligence and athleticism rather than the environment or choice

"If instructors teach genetics to help students understand the flaws in genetic essentialist arguments, then it is possible to reduce belief in genetic essentialism among biology students"

Humane Genetics

(Donovan, 2021)



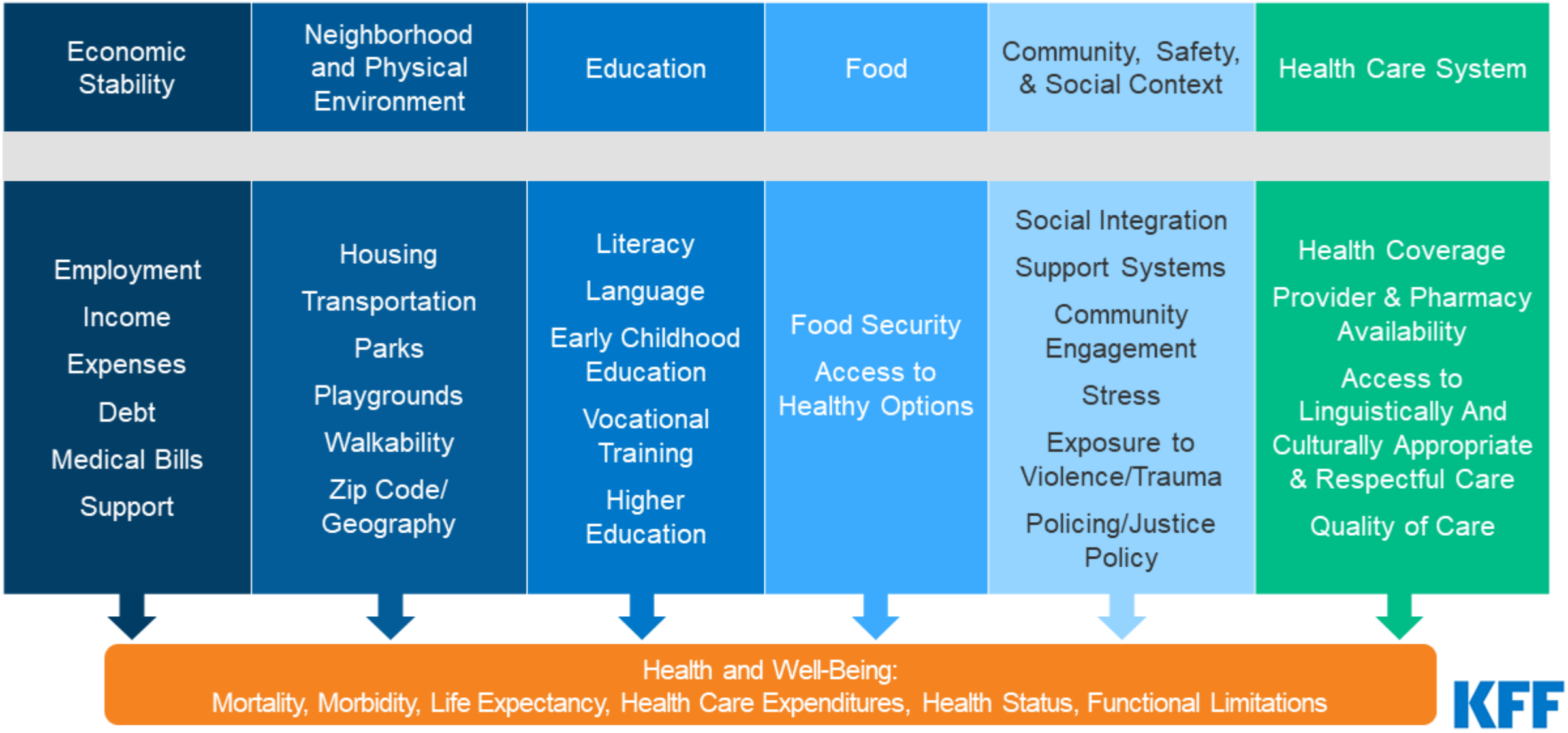
Social determinants of health

“The social determinants of health (SDH) are **the non-medical factors that influence health outcomes**. They are the conditions in which people are born, grow, work, live, and age, and the wider set of forces and systems shaping the conditions of daily life. These forces and systems include economic policies and systems, development agendas, social norms, social policies and political systems.”

World Health Organization



Social Determinants of Health



KFF

Example:

Education

- Literacy
- Language
- Early Childhood Education
- Vocational Training
- Higher Education

Health and Well-Being:
Mortality, Morbidity, Life Expectancy, Health Care Expenditures, Health Status, Functional Limitations

Education & Health

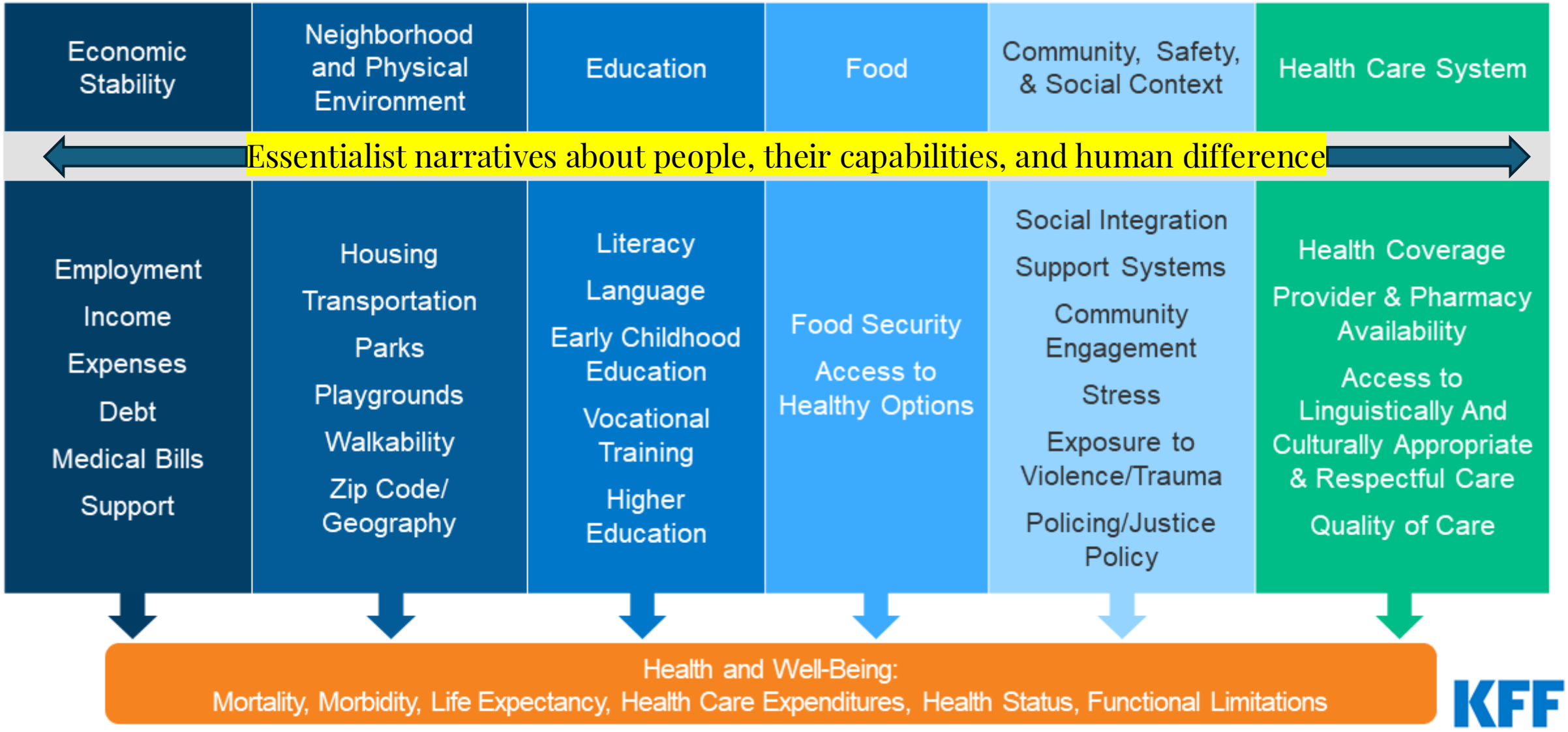
- Adults with more education live healthier and longer lives compared to less educated peers
- Many health outcomes have been found to be strongly patterned by education
  - Education increases the chances that a person accesses quality healthcare, finds employment that pays a living wage, and lives in a safe, non-polluted environment

↓

Education is strongly associated with life expectancy and morbidity



Social Determinants of Health



Example:

Health Care System

- Health Coverage
- Provider and Pharmacy Availability
- Access to Linguistically And Culturally Appropriate & Respectful Care
- Quality of care

Health and Well-Being:
Mortality, Morbidity, Life Expectancy, Health Care Expenditures, Health Status, Functional Limitations



Racial essentialism in pain assessment and treatment

"A substantial number of white laypeople and medical students and residents hold false beliefs about biological differences between blacks and whites" (Hoffman et al, 2016)

- E.g., black people's skin is thicker than white people's skin; black people are drug seeking

↓

These beliefs predict racial bias in pain perception and treatment recommendation accuracy (Hoffman et al, 2016)


GREAT SEAL OF THE HAVASUPAI TRIBE 1880
HAVSUW' BAAJA



Datafication of injustice

What is the relationship between social determinants of health and justice?





What do social determinants have to do with justice?

Remember **Daniels**:

- As a matter of justice, what do we owe each other to promote and protect health in a population and to assist people when they are ill or disabled?
- Health inequalities are unjust when they derive from unjust/unfair distribution of **socially controllable factors** affecting population health and its distribution

Daniels & Rawls on Social Determinants of Health

- Each person has the same indefeasible claim to a fully adequate scheme of **equal basic liberties**

- Society is tasked with fairly distributing **primary social goods** like:
  - Rights & liberties (e.g., political participation)
  - Powers and opportunities (e.g., basic education)
  - Income and wealth

- Social goods are to be distributed equally unless an unequal distribution of any, or all, of these values is to everyone's advantage

- The equal and fair distribution of social goods flattens/regulates social determinants of health
  - If everyone has the same opportunity to access a quality education; then they have equal access to the health benefits that come from education



Daniels & Rawls on Social Determinants of Health



1. Social determinants have an impact on health

2. Health is of special moral importance because it protects people's ability to function normally

3. Ability to function normally affects the range of opportunities available to a person

4. Social determinants of health affect a person’s ability to function normally and the opportunities they can access

5. Thus, to meet health needs fairly we ought to, as best as possible, regulate social determinants of health (e.g., provide equal opportunity to the basic liberties and social goods that Rawls discusses)

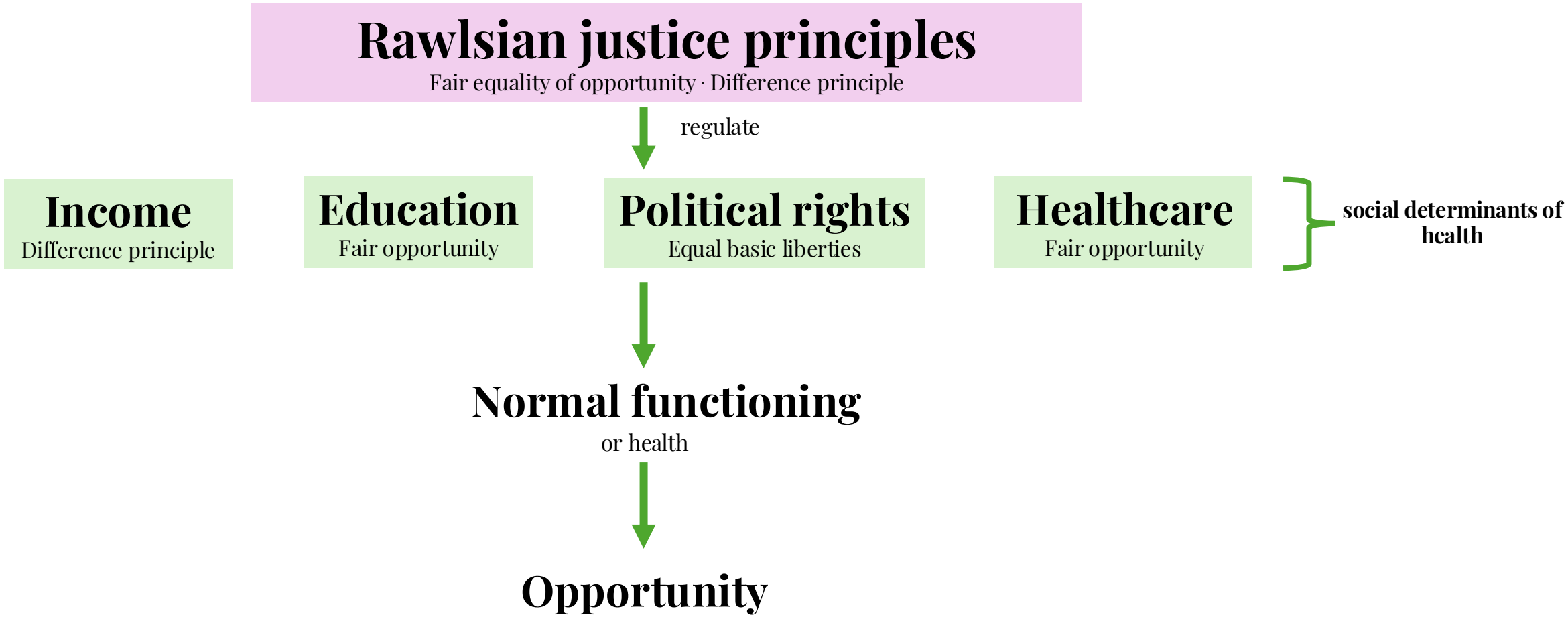
What do social determinants have to do with justice?

Justice means…

- Achieving sufficient level of well-being in health, self determination, respect of others, etc.
- Combatting emergence and persistence of systematic disadvantage that undermine the achievement of sufficient level of health

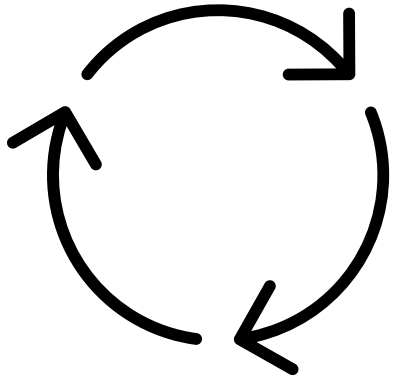


Social justice: promoting fairness, equality, equity and rights across multiple aspects of society, including economic, educational, and workforce opportunities. (Killen et al, 2022)

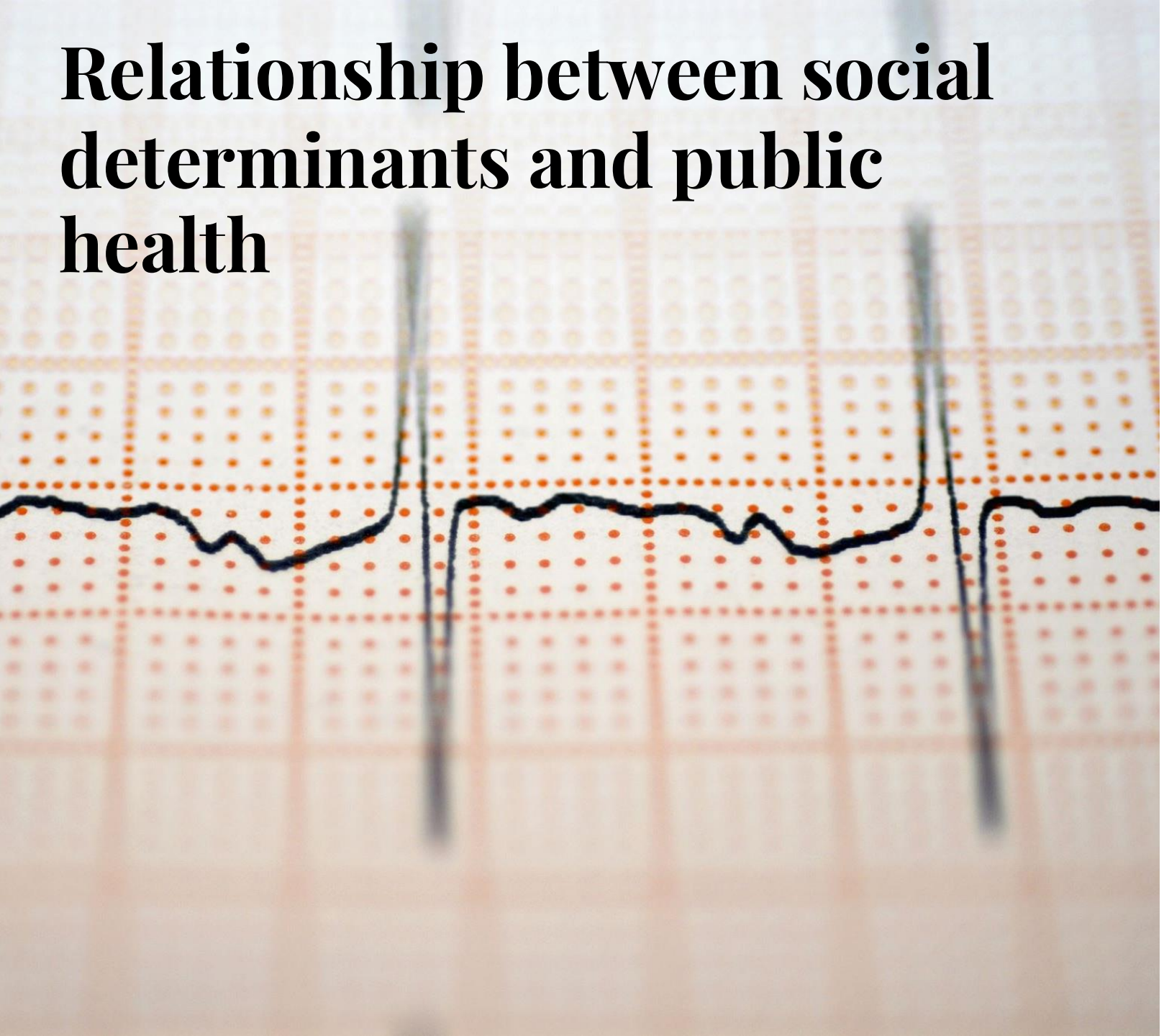

Rawlsian justice principles
Fair equality of opportunity · Difference principle
regulate
Income
Difference principle
Education
Fair opportunity
Political rights
Equal basic liberties
Healthcare
Fair opportunity
social determinants of health
Normal functioning
or health
Opportunity



- Social determinants shape health
- Therefore social determinants can undermine the achievement of a sufficient level of health
- Social determinants create health injustice (e.g., unfair inequalities in health outcomes)
- Social determinants also arise out of injustice (e.g., ableism is a social determinant of health)



Relationship between social determinants and public health



“Public health is what we do together as a society to ensure the conditions in which everyone can be healthy”

(Khoury et al 2022)

Leaving you with a question:

How do research and biotechnology infrastructure impact justice concerns in health care?

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